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Abstract

This paper critically explores the junction of eco-horror films and capitalist structures, focusing on how contemporary narratives in films like Gaia (2021) and In the Earth (2021) ambivalently critique and at the same time reinforce the fabric of capitalist exploitation of our material world. These films reflect anxieties about environmental collapse but often fail to challenge the deeper systemic forces driving ecological destruction. It aims to identify the evasive tendencies perpetuated through the climate fictions that obscure the structural and material causes of ecological crises shaped by human intervention and industrial exploitation. The critique draws on theorists like Slavoj Žižek who argues against romanticizing Nature as a harmonious entity disrupted by humans and Amitav Ghosh, who testifies to the fact that modernist narratives often tend to isolate climate crises from their systemic roots. Ultimately, it concludes by evoking the demand for eco-narratives critically concerned with the apportionment of capitalism in ecological catastrophes, going beyond aestheticized fear and mysticism towards a more grounded, systemic critique of ecological collapse.

Keywords: Eco-narrative, Climate, Capitalism, Anthropocentrism, Nature.

1. An Analysis of Systemic Forces

In Jaco Bouwer's *Gaia*, the film's narrative and imagery create a complex intersection between eco-horror and capitalism's underlying logic of extraction and commodification, making it a compelling case for critical analysis through the lens of eco-narratives and global capitalism, as outlined in the theoretical framework of the paper.

Gaia serves as a striking representation of Nature's retribution against human exploitation, yet it equivocally upholds and critiques capitalist dynamics. The film, set in a remote forest where nature appears to rise against humanity through a primordial fungal organism, evokes the Anthropocene as a time of reckoning. However, beneath its environmentalist veneer lies a deeper ideological critique—how capitalism continues to appropriate ecological discourse to further its own ends. By examining *Gaia* through the theoretical framework of eco-dystopian narratives, as developed in the earlier chapter, we can uncover how the film both critiques and inadvertently supports the capitalist system it seeks to question. Drawing from the commodification of social realities and the manipulation of ecological crises outlined in the previous chapter, *Gaia* offers fertile ground for a discussion on how capitalism is not only complicit in environmental destruction but also seeks to rehabilitate itself through eco-narratives.

At its core, *Gaia* uses the imagery of an ancient and sentient forest to tap into contemporary anxieties around environmental collapse. The protagonists, on an expedition to maintain a surveillance drone, stumble upon an isolated father and son living a quasi-

religious existence, worshipping a mysterious fungal deity (5:25). The film quickly transforms into an exploration of Nature's grotesque power to reclaim what humanity has sought to dominate (35:46). However, this reclamation is not merely an eco-horror fantasy; it reflects a deep-seated guilt embedded within global capitalist narratives, where Nature's revolt becomes both punishment and salvation. From the outset, *Gaia* positions humanity in opposition to Nature, which has become a recurring trope in eco-dystopian films. The father and son's retreat from civilization into the forest evokes a sense of escape from the clutches of capitalist modernity, echoing the critique of capitalism's commodification of life and Nature as evidenced in the previous chapter. Yet, their worship of the fungal organism suggests that even in their rejection of modernity (44:02), they remain beholden to a higher power that demands submission—mirroring the very logic of capitalism that exploits both labor and Nature under the guise of freedom and autonomy. As the film progresses, the fungal deity they worship starts resembling capitalism's cyclical nature. It consumes the bodies of the protagonists, reshaping them into new life forms (50:38), much like capitalism extracts and consumes resources, only to regenerate and continue its process of accumulation. The horrifying symbiosis between human and Nature in *Gaia* can be read as an allegory for how capitalism co-opts ecological narratives to perpetuate itself. Just as the characters are subsumed by the fungal network, global capitalism appropriates ecological discourse, positioning itself as both the cause and potential saviour in the face of environmental catastrophe.

The film's depiction of Nature as a powerful, vengeful force aligns with the secularized myth of the 'Fall'¹, where humanity's hubris leads to Nature's retaliation, a narrative that Slavoj Žižek critiques for its ideological underpinnings. Žižek in his book *Living in the*

End Times critiques the traditional understanding of the story of the 'Fall', particularly how it has been secularized and embedded within contemporary ecological thinking. He argues that the common narrative of Nature as a harmonious, balanced totality, which is then disrupted by human hubris, exploitation, and technological advancement, is essentially a modern, secular version of the religious story of the 'Fall' (ch. 2). In this framework, humans are seen as the original sinners who have caused Nature to lose its balance, and the environmental catastrophes we face today are framed as Nature's retaliation for these transgressions. Žižek challenges this view, stating that the idea of a harmonious Nature disturbed by humanity is a myth. According to him, Nature is not a balanced, organic system but rather a series of chaotic, catastrophic events. He dismisses the notion that humanity has corrupted an otherwise stable and peaceful natural world, instead proposing that Nature itself is inherently chaotic and unpredictable. Žižek argues that this romanticized idea of a pure Nature disturbed by humans merely masks the complexities and inherent violence of nature itself. (ch. 2)

This aligns with the proposed argument on how Hollywood eco-dystopias create a sense of guilt while supporting the status quo of capitalist consumption. In *Gaia*, the forest and its fungal deity act as the embodiment of Nature's rage, punishing humanity for its sins. Yet, the underlying depiction ultimately reinforces the capitalist narrative that Nature, like any other commodity, is something that can be restored and controlled through proper management—ironically supporting the logic of eco-capitalism².

However, the commodification of Nature is starkly represented in the film's aesthetic. The forest, while depicted as threatening, is also visually lush, almost inviting in its danger. This ambivalence reflects how contemporary capitalist systems commodify Nature,

transforming it into something to be consumed aesthetically and ideologically, even as it threatens to destroy humanity. This tension between fear and desire mirrors how the global capitalist market commodifies ecological disaster, offering green solutions and eco-friendly commodities while continuing to exploit natural resources—a theme central to the theoretical framework of this paper.

In *Gaia*, the fungal organism represents not just Nature's wrath but also the capitalist system's ability to regenerate through crisis. The characters' futile attempts to escape the forest mirror humanity's entrapment in the capitalist system, where attempts at resistance often lead to further entanglement. The symbiotic relationship between human and fungus in the film can be read as a metaphor for how capitalism co-opts environmental concerns, integrating them into its cycle of consumption and regeneration, ensuring its survival even in the face of ecological collapse. By positioning Nature as both the victim and agent of capitalism's excesses, *Gaia* underscores how eco-narratives are ideologically constructed to perpetuate the very system they critique. Thus, the film becomes a site for examining how global capitalism thrives on crises, repurposing ecological destruction as yet another opportunity for consumption and accumulation, exemplifying the dynamic of eco-dystopian films that address climate trauma while reinforcing the very logic of the capitalist system responsible for it.

2. Demystifying the Mystery

Ben Wheatley's *In the Earth* is a film that grapples with humanity's fractured relationship with the natural world, presenting nature as both mystical and menacing. Set during a global pandemic, the film reflects contemporary fears surrounding environmental

collapse and human fragility. However, while *In the Earth* addresses ecological concerns and humanity's impact on the environment, its narrative falls short in critically engaging with these issues in a meaningful or transformative way. By veiling Nature in mysticism and eco spirituality, the film obscures the deeper, materialist concerns around ecology, offering a reductive view of both Nature and humanity's role in environmental degradation. Steeped in the mysticism of Nature, the film portrays the forest as a sentient, omnipotent force that communicates through cryptic symbols³ (35:53) and an inexplicable fungal network. While this mystical depiction of Nature adds a layer of horror to the film, it also limits the scope of its ecological critique. Instead of presenting Nature as a dynamic system shaped by human exploitation and industrial activity, the film leans heavily on the trope of Nature as an unknowable and vengeful entity. This mystification of Nature diverts attention from the real, tangible issues of environmental degradation. The ecological crisis we face today is a result of deforestation, pollution, climate change, and other anthropogenic forces that are well documented and scientifically understood. However, Wheatley's *In the Earth* bypasses these material concerns, opting instead to present Nature as an almost spiritual force that operates beyond human understanding. This approach reduces Nature to a mysterious antagonist, distancing the film from the pressing realities of ecological collapse and environmental destruction. While the mystical portrayal of Nature can serve as a powerful narrative device, it risks oversimplifying the complexities of ecological systems and our role within them. By treating Nature as an unknowable entity, Wheatley's *In the Earth* undermines the potential for a more grounded, rationally informed critique of environmental exploitation. It leans into the idea that Nature operates on a higher, incomprehensible level, rather than engaging with the ways in which human actions and

industrial activities have directly and systematically harmed the environment. Although it is true that our planet's ecosystem or its natural disposition is arbitrary in nature and the finitude of human episteme falls short to comprehend this complex disposition of the natural world, it is important to address the real issues which humans are in a dialectical relationship with.

One of the central themes in *In the Earth* is the idea of Nature as a source of healing and spiritual renewal. The characters in the film embark on a journey to study and interact with Nature, hoping to unlock its hidden powers using scientific tools, almost performing an ancient ritual (1:09:00). However, this narrative arc falls into the trap of eco-spiritualism, where Nature is romanticized as something pure, powerful, and ultimately redemptive. This type of narrative is often appealing because it suggests that humanity can heal its relationship with Nature through spiritual or personal awakening. However, this approach is inherently limiting when it comes to addressing the systemic nature of the ecological crisis. The environmental destruction we face is not merely the result of humanity's estrangement from Nature or a lack of spiritual connection with the earth; it is the product of centuries of industrial exploitation, resource extraction, and unsustainable practices driven by economic imperatives. By framing the ecological crisis as something that can be resolved through a spiritual reconnection with Nature, the film sidesteps the need for systemic change.

The film's characters, particularly those who are portrayed as in tune with Nature, offer no real solutions to the ecological problems they face. Instead, they become part of the forest's enigmatic ecosystem, blending into its violent, destructive rhythms. This narrative, while atmospheric, fails to grapple with the urgent need for structural changes to how we

need to engage our ecological thinking with our material world which we benefit from. It avoids addressing the political and economic forces driving environmental degradation, offering instead an individualized, mystical solution that ignores the larger, collective action required to combat the climate crisis.

However, this spectacle of Nature as a violent and unyielding force serves as a powerful commentary on the unpredictability and indifference of ecological systems. It can be argued that the natural world is not designed to cater to human needs, and ecological collapse could be seen as a consequence of humanity's attempts to control and dominate an indifferent, chaotic system. But the film misses the opportunity to deepen this narrative, leaving it underdeveloped. Rather than exploring the consequences of humanity's attempts to dominate and manipulate Nature, the film treats Nature's violence as something mystical and unexplained. This approach detracts from the film's potential to offer a meaningful critique of humanity's dialectical relationship with the environment. Instead of delving into the ecological reasons behind Nature's violent outburst—such as the consequences of deforestation, climate change, and loss of biodiversity—the film falls back on a more mystical interpretation, leaving viewers without a clear sense of the systemic causes behind ecological breakdown. The film offers a haunting depiction of Nature's untameable power but lacks the critical depth needed to engage with the complexities of the ecological crisis in a meaningful way. The film's failure to address systemic issues, and its reliance on mysticism, leaves it adrift in the sea of eco-horror films that gesture towards ecological concerns without fully interrogating them.

3. Commenting on Distorted Spiritualism

In both *Gaia* (2021) and *In the Earth* (2021), the notion of ‘saviour complex’⁴ functions as a narrative tool that shapes how the relationship between humans and Nature is depicted, ultimately reinforcing rather than challenging the capitalist structures that drive environmental destruction. This moral injunction frames Nature as something that either punishes humanity or holds the key to its salvation, offering a simplified view of ecological crises that obscures the underlying systemic issues.

In *Gaia*, the forest and its fungal organism embody a vengeful Nature that punishes humans for their environmental sins. The characters are caught between confronting this wrath or submitting to it, and these dynamic positions Nature’s violence as a response to human exploitation. The portrayal suggests that Nature’s retribution serves a corrective function, almost as if humanity can redeem itself by yielding to Nature’s power. This mechanism abstracts the real issues behind ecological collapse, treating environmental destruction as a moral failing to be corrected, rather than a structural problem rooted in capitalist exploitation. The exhibition of horror loaded with moral injunctions in the narrative reduces the complexity of ecological systems and shifts the focus away from systemic change, suggesting that humanity’s relationship with Nature can be restored through individual submission, rather than addressing the root causes of environmental crises.

In *In the Earth*, the relationship between humans and Nature is framed through a mystical lens, where the characters seek to unlock Nature’s hidden powers as a means of understanding or salvation. This spiritualized depiction of Nature, as something that holds the solution to humanity’s problems, feeds into a moral compulsion, suggesting that humanity can restore its balance with Nature by engaging with its mysteries. This obscures

the material realities of environmental degradation and shifts the narrative into a realm of eco spiritualism. By portraying Nature as an enigmatic force to be understood rather than a system impacted by human actions, the film distances itself from the need for collective action or systemic reform. It perpetuates the idea that individual enlightenment or alignment with Nature can save humanity, which ultimately reinforces a depoliticized, eco-capitalist narrative.

In both films, Nature's portrayal as a vengeful entity functions as a double-edged sword. On one hand, it evokes contemporary anxieties about environmental collapse, positioning Nature as a force that demands retribution for humanity's exploitation. On the other hand, this notion of vengeance is appropriated by eco-capitalist narratives, which commodify the crisis and frame ecological problems as something that can be managed or corrected through personal action or submission to Nature's might. By depicting Nature as something that punishes and redeems, these films risk reinforcing the capitalist logic that ecological crises are reversible through moral correction, rather than through dismantling the structures that perpetuate environmental harm.

The portrayal of Nature as a vengeful force is problematic because it externalizes the responsibility for ecological collapse. It suggests that Nature's anger is a response to humanity's actions, but it fails to engage with the systemic exploitation and industrial forces that have led to environmental destruction. This framing reduces the need for systemic change, positioning the ecological crisis as a moral issue rather than a political and economic one. By focusing on Nature's revenge, the films shift the burden of responsibility onto individuals, implying that ecological redemption lies in personal actions rather than addressing the broader capitalist structures that drive exploitation.

In *Archaeologies of the Future* Fredric Jameson explores science fiction as a genre that offers a unique platform for utopian thinking but also critically assesses its limitations, particularly within the context of late capitalism. He argues that science fiction becomes a tool through which society can project its hopes and fears for the future. However, according to Jameson, under capitalism, imagining a truly different world becomes difficult. This idea can further be demonstrated in case of ecological thinking as well. (10)

Jaco Bouwer's *Gaia* depicts a world in which Nature's wrath is unleashed through a primordial fungal organism, symbolizing a retributive force against human exploitation. However, while the film presents the forest as a site of Nature's vengeance, it fails to imagine any transformative alternative to the capitalist structures that led to this destruction. The characters are trapped within the logic of survival, and the narrative ultimately reinforces the cyclical nature of capitalist crisis management—Nature punishes, but no systemic change occurs. The film's vision of the future is deeply constrained by the present capitalist framework, where nature's wrath becomes yet another catastrophe to be endured, rather than an opportunity to imagine a new ecological or social order.

Gaia does not propose a future beyond the ecological devastation caused by capitalism; instead, it frames Nature's retaliation as an inevitable consequence of human actions, while leaving the capitalist system that underpins this destruction untouched. The forest, though hostile and vengeful, is portrayed as a timeless force, detached from the socio-economic structures that have exploited it. In this sense, the film mirrors the limitations of capitalist realism, where the ecological crisis is acknowledged but no radical alternatives to the system that caused it are envisioned. This is not a failure of imagination in a traditional sense, but rather a symptom of how narratives are shaped by the economic and ideological

constraints of the present.

Similarly, *In the Earth* presents a mystical and surreal engagement with Nature, where the characters seek to understand and commune with an omnipotent, fungal network. The film leans heavily into eco-spiritualism, suggesting that humanity's salvation lies in unlocking the secrets of nature. Yet, like *Gaia*, it does not offer a critique of the systems that have driven humanity to the brink of ecological collapse. Instead, *In the Earth* mystifies Nature, presenting it as a force beyond human comprehension, further detaching the narrative from the material realities of environmental degradation. The film's focus on the mystical properties of the natural world reduces the ecological crisis to a metaphysical problem, sidelining the socio-political dimensions that are embedded within the gamut of ecological thinking.

Both *Gaia* and *In the Earth* reflect this narrative inadequacy by mystifying or isolating Nature, reducing the global climate crisis to a localised or spiritual phenomenon, rather than engaging with broader systemic forces that drive environmental destruction. These films not only fail to adequately address the material realities of climate change but also contribute to a kind of aestheticized derangement, where Nature's wrath is divorced from human history and responsibility, particularly capitalism's role in ecological degradation.

Gaia portrays Nature as a hostile, sentient force that exacts revenge on humanity through a fungal organism. This representation accentuates the purpose of climate narratives that focus on isolated, almost mythic events, rather than engaging with the larger forces of industrialization and capitalism that are at the root of ecological crises. The forest in *Gaia* becomes a site of retribution, but this retribution is framed as something almost

mystical or divine, disconnected from the real economic systems that drive environmental destruction.

In *Gaia*, the eco-horror is rendered as a personal experience of survival against Nature's revenge, rather than an exploration of the broader socio-political context that has led to ecological collapse. The film focuses on the struggle of a few characters against a powerful and grotesque natural force, without delving into the larger systems that created the conditions for this revenge. This reduction of the climate crisis to an isolated encounter aligns with Amitav Ghosh's argument that contemporary storytelling often isolates climate-related events, making them feel detached from history, politics, and global capitalism. (Ghosh, *Derangement* ch. 3).

In the film, *In the Earth*, the characters' journey into the forest is framed as a quest for understanding or enlightenment, suggesting that the climate crisis can be understood or resolved through spiritual or personal discovery. This mystical framing, however, distracts from the urgent material realities of deforestation, pollution, and climate change, which are systemic issues driven by global capitalism. The film's reliance on eco-spiritualism reflects the pressing concern that modern narratives often resort to romanticized depictions of Nature, which obscure the complexities of human impact on the environment. Rather than engaging with the anthropogenic forces behind climate change, *In the Earth* displaces responsibility onto an abstract, unknowable force, failing to confront the real, systemic origins of the crisis.

By focusing on Nature's vengeance or mysticism, *Gaia* and *In the Earth* contribute to a form of narrative displacement, where the true complexity and urgency of climate change

are sidestepped in favour of personal or spiritual experiences. This can be critiqued as a form of narrative failure—by turning the ecological crisis into a spectacle of fear or awe, these films avoid confronting the deeper realities of global capitalism's role in environmental destruction. The climate crisis becomes a matter of individual survival or mystical enlightenment, rather than a collective challenge that requires systemic change.

Moreover, this mystification of Nature reflects a broader cultural tendency to distance the climate crisis from human agency. Amitav Ghosh argues that this distancing is a central feature of "the great derangement" (Ghosh, ch.3)—the inability to reckon with the scale of the problem, both in narrative and in reality. In these films, nature is portrayed as an antagonistic force beyond human control or comprehension, rather than a system deeply shaped by human exploitation. This framing allows the films to avoid addressing the need for systemic change, presenting the crisis as something that can be endured, but not transformed.

4. Conclusion

So, this paper ultimately underscores the critical need for a shift in how we approach environmental issues. It is imperative that we move beyond the superficial narratives perpetuated by the institutions of political economy and media representations to confront the deeper, structural challenges that impede genuine progress. This involves questioning and challenging the ideologies and practices that effectuate environmental commoditization and embracing a more holistic, systemic perspective on ecological stewardship, offering an authentic commitment to environmental issues to create a more sustainable future.

Notes

1. The myth of the Fall refers to the story of humanity's descent from an original state of innocence or harmony into a condition of sin, corruption, or moral degradation. In the Judeo-Christian tradition, this is most famously represented in the biblical account of Adam and Eve in the Book of Genesis. According to the myth, Adam and Eve lived in the Garden of Eden in a state of purity until they disobeyed God's command by eating from the Tree of Knowledge. This act, influenced by the serpent's temptation, led to their expulsion from Eden and introduced sin, suffering, and mortality into the world.
2. Eco-capitalism, also known as green capitalism, refers to an economic approach that seeks to address environmental issues within the framework of capitalism. It promotes the idea that market-driven solutions, technological innovation, and sustainable business practices can solve environmental challenges, such as climate change, deforestation, and pollution, while still maintaining economic growth.
3. In the film *In the Earth* (2021), cryptic symbols play a central role in establishing the mysterious and unsettling atmosphere. These symbols are associated with the film's themes of nature, ancient rituals, and a supernatural connection to the earth.
4. The saviour complex (also known as hero syndrome) refers to a psychological state in which an individual feels an overwhelming desire or need to 'save' others, often in ways that go beyond normal caregiving or altruism. People with a saviour complex may believe that they are uniquely capable of solving others' problems and may

intervene even when it is not necessary or wanted. This behaviour can sometimes stem from a deep-seated need for validation, a desire for control, or unresolved personal issues. While well-intentioned, the saviour complex can become problematic when it undermines others' autonomy, fosters dependency, or leads to burnout in the saviour. It can also be harmful when it distracts from addressing systemic issues, as the focus shifts to individual heroism rather than collective solutions.

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